on the condition that they learn the local language, wear no armour and that the women wear the local attire.[5] They did this, along with building a Parsi fire temple that dates back to 721 CE. For the next 300 years, their tribe would grow and move to other parts of India such as Cambay, Anklesvar, Surat, Variav and Vankaner north of Sanjan and Thana to the south. However, the sources are not clear about whether these migrations took place from Sanjan or directly from Persia. In 1142 CE, they were traced to Navsari and a few other parts of the Indian subcontinent in subsequent centuries. References to Parsis in historical records often come from travellers' observations about their distinct cultural practices such as that of Oderic, an Italian monk in India in the early 14th century:[6]

> The people thereof (Thana) are idolaters, for they worship fire and serpents and trees also, and here they do not bury the dead, but carry them with great pomp to the fields and cast them to the beasts and birds to be devoured.

War-related disturbances saw the Zoroastrian 'sacred fire' move to different places: Navsari in 1419, Surat in 1733 and Udvada in 1742, where it burns till date. In the 17th century, when a doctor was visiting Bombay in 1671, the Parsis were documented there for the first time. The doctor had noted a Parsi tomb on top of Malabar Hill.[7] The English East India Company had acquired Bombay in 1668 after the Portuguese ceded the islands to England in 1661 as part of a dowry when the Portuguese Infanta Catherine and the English King Charles II got married.[8] The link between the Parsis and the Company, and Surat and Bombay, would be crucial in the next phase of Parsi migration as the economy of Surat declined compared to that of Bombay in the 18th century. These links would be forged in shipping, trading and tax farming.

The records of the East India Company mention Cursett, a Parsi shipbuilder, in Surat in the late 17th century.[9] Much later, Lowjee Nusserwanji Wadia, a Parsi foreman of a shipping agent in Surat, was brought over to Bombay by the Company to build the Bombay dockyard. The dockyard built over 350 wooden ships between the middle of the 18th and end of the 19th centuries and drew in a large number of carpenters and